STATE SCAN

JAMMU & KASHMIR: RUINED BY STATECRAFT *PG 17*

GUJARAT: THE GRIM REAPER STRIKES *PG 18*



ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

ARROWS FOR THE 'ENEMY' Men from Rakhelguda village in Odisha's Malkangiri district stage a protest, Dec. 8

▶ ODISHA

KEEPING BENGALI MIGRANTS AT BAY

A village burnt, traders arrested, labourers attacked—what began as anti-Bangladeshi vigilantism in Odisha ends up as a rising tide of anti-Bengali xenophobia

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

THE LINE SLICING BENGAL AND ODISHA into two is a modern cartographer's invention. In its original form, Dandabhukti was one lifeworld—a web spun by rivers, merchants, pilgrims, deities, poets, artists and motifs. The Bay of Bengal coastline did not divide. It unified. If history's contrasts are to be seen sharpened to an extreme, late 2025 is a good time. A drive against undocumented immigration in Odisha, after the flavour of the season, has slipped dangerously into a high tide of suspicion, hate and violence. The targets: Bengali-speaking migrants.

The stories surfacing across Odisha are unsettling in their similarity—being Muslim and Bengali simultaneously might as well be a prima facie crime. In Nayagarh, just before December, four small-time traders from Murshidabad were accosted by police and told to pack up within 72 hours. Their Aadhaar cards and voter IDs were waved away, their Bengali accents turned into instant proof of "foreignness". The men fled, leaving behind goods worth lakhs—winter garments and other utilities. In August, eight